

BONUS 3 OF 5

Lining, Zipper & Hardware Guide

How to line without puckering, add a zipper without warping and secure straps that hold weight.

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SECTION 1

Choosing Lining Fabric

Pick the right fabric for your backpack's purpose so the lining lasts as long as the crochet shell.

Not all lining fabrics work the same way inside crochet. You need something that slides easily against the yarn, resists snagging, and matches the bag's intended use.

Fabric Types at a Glance

FABRIC	WEIGHT	BEST FOR	WASHABLE?
Cotton quilting fabric	Light–medium	Everyday bags, beginners	Yes — machine wash
Cotton canvas	Medium–heavy	Large backpacks that carry weight	Yes — machine wash
Polyester lining (Bemsilk)	Very light	Small clutches, decorative bags	Yes — gentle cycle
Nylon ripstop	Light	Water-resistant bags, gym packs	Yes — air dry
Home decor cotton–linen blend	Medium	Structured totes, laptop compartments	Yes — cold wash

How to Decide

- 1 Consider the bag's job** — a gym backpack needs water-resistant nylon; a toddler's bag needs machine-washable cotton.
- 2 Check the drape** — hold the fabric over your hand. If it stands stiff like cardboard, it will fight the crochet shell. You want gentle structure, not rigidity.
- 3 Test for snagging** — rub the wrong side of the fabric against a swatch of your yarn. If fibers catch or pull, pick a smoother option.
- 4 Match the weight** — the lining should be lighter than or equal to the crochet shell. A heavy lining inside a lightweight bag will drag and distort the shape.

Good Practice

Pre-wash and iron the lining fabric before cutting. Cotton can shrink up to 5% on the first wash. If you skip this, the lining may pucker after the bag's first wash.

Common Mistake

Using satin or silk. These fabrics are too slippery and too delicate — seams pull apart under weight, and the shine collects dust and lint inside the bag.

Quick Check Before You Buy

- ☐ The fabric does not snag when rubbed against my yarn
- ☐ It can be washed the same way as the finished bag
- ☐ The weight is equal to or lighter than the crochet shell
- ☐ I have enough yardage plus 10% for seam allowance and errors

SECTION 2

How to Measure & Cut Lining

Get clean panels that fit your finished bag without bunching or pulling.

Crochet fabric stretches. Woven lining does not. The key is to measure the bag in its resting shape — not stretched flat — and add the right allowances.

Step by Step

- 1 Block or steam the bag first** — let it rest in its natural shape for at least one hour after blocking. Measure only after it has relaxed.
- 2 Measure height and width** — place the bag flat. Measure from the inside bottom to the top opening edge. Then measure the widest point across the opening.
- 3 Measure depth (gusset)** — if the bag has a separate base or side panel, measure from one side seam across the bottom to the other side seam.
- 4 Add seam allowance** — add 1.5 cm (5/8 in.) to every edge. This gives you room to fold and sew without eating into the panel.
- 5 Subtract 0.5 cm (1/4 in.) from height** — the lining should sit just below the top edge so it is hidden. This prevents the fabric from peeking out.
- 6 Cut on grain** — align the fabric grain (the lengthwise threads) with the height of the bag. This prevents diagonal stretch and keeps the lining hanging straight.
- 7 Label each panel** — use a fabric marker or chalk to write "front," "back," "base," etc. on the wrong side. It saves confusion during assembly.

Seam Allowance Quick Reference

EDGE TYPE	ALLOWANCE	WHY
Side seams	1.5 cm / 5/8 in.	Standard for home-sewing machines
Top fold (opening)	2 cm / 3/4 in.	Gives a clean fold for whip-stitching to the bag
Bottom seam	1.5 cm / 5/8 in.	Matches side seams for consistent fit
Pocket openings	2.5 cm / 1 in.	Allows a double fold for a neat, reinforced edge

Good Practice

Cut a paper template first. Pin it inside the bag and check the fit before cutting the actual fabric. Adjust once on paper instead of wasting fabric.

Common Mistake

Measuring the bag while it is stretched flat on a table. Crochet fabric relaxes when lifted. Always measure with the bag upright or gently held in shape.

Before You Cut

- ☐ Fabric is pre-washed and ironed
- ☐ Bag is blocked and resting in natural shape
- ☐ I have a paper template that fits snugly inside the bag
- ☐ Seam allowances are marked on the fabric (not just in my head)
- ☐ Each panel is labeled on the wrong side

SECTION 3

Sewing the Lining In

Attach lining by hand with a clean, invisible finish that lies flat.

You do not need a sewing machine for this. Hand-sewing gives you more control over tension — which matters because crochet and woven fabric behave differently.

What You Need

- Your cut and pressed lining panels
- Sewing needle (sharp, not a yarn needle)
- Matching thread (polyester all-purpose)
- Straight pins or sewing clips
- Thimble (optional but recommended for thick crochet)

Assembly Order

- 1 **Sew the lining bag first** — stitch the side seams and bottom seam of the lining panels together using a backstitch (by hand) or a straight stitch (by machine). Press seams open or to one side.
- 2 **Add internal pockets now** — if you want a phone pocket or a zip pocket inside, sew it to the lining panel before inserting. It is much easier to work on flat fabric than inside a finished bag.
- 3 **Fold the top edge** — fold the top edge of the lining bag inward by 2 cm (3/4 in.) and press with an iron. This gives you a clean folded edge to stitch to the crochet.
- 4 **Insert wrong side out** — place the lining bag (wrong side facing out) inside the crochet bag (right side facing out). The wrong sides of both should now touch each other.
- 5 **Pin in place** — align the folded top edge of the lining about 1 cm (3/8 in.) below the top edge of the crochet opening. Pin or clip every 3–4 cm around the opening.
- 6 **Whip-stitch around the opening** — use a sharp needle and matching thread. Stitch through the fold of the lining and through the back loop of the crochet stitches along the top row. Keep stitches small (3–4 mm apart) and even tension.

- 7 Tack the bottom corners** — add 3–4 tacking stitches at each bottom corner to anchor the lining base to the crochet base. This prevents the lining from riding up when the bag is loaded.

Good Practice

Work with the bag turned inside out over your fist so you can see both the lining edge and the crochet stitches clearly. Flip right-side out every few centimeters to check alignment.

Common Mistake

Pulling the thread too tight. This causes the crochet fabric to pucker inward at the top opening. Keep the thread with gentle, even tension — the lining should lie flat, not pull.

Stitch Options for Attaching Lining

STITCH	VISIBILITY	STRENGTH	BEST FOR
Whip stitch	Nearly invisible from outside	Good	Most bags (recommended default)
Backstitch	Visible as a line inside	Very strong	Heavy-duty bags that carry weight
Slip stitch (sewing)	Invisible on both sides	Moderate	Decorative bags where inside is visible

After Sewing In

- ☐ Lining top sits 0.5–1 cm below the crochet opening edge
- ☐ No puckering visible from the outside
- ☐ Bottom corners are tacked so lining does not ride up
- ☐ Internal pockets are accessible and lie flat
- ☐ Thread ends are knotted and trimmed inside

SECTION 4

Installing Zippers

Add a top zipper or an interior zip pocket without warping the crochet fabric.

Zippers and crochet can work together smoothly, but only if you use the right type and anchor the zipper to the lining – not directly to the crochet stitches.

Zipper Types Compared

ZIPPER TYPE	TEETH	BEST USE	DIFFICULTY
Nylon coil (regular)	Flexible, lightweight	Top closures, interior pockets	Easy
Molded plastic (Vislon-style)	Rigid, chunky	Large openings on structured bags	Moderate
Invisible / concealed	Hidden behind tape	Bags where you want a seamless look	Moderate
Metal (brass / nickel)	Heavy, durable	Decorative accents, heavy-duty packs	Hard (needs strong needle)

Installing a Top Zipper (Nylon Coil)

- 1 Measure the opening** — measure the length of the bag opening from one side seam to the other. Buy a zipper that is 2–3 cm (1 in.) longer than this measurement; you will trim the excess.
- 2 Prepare a fabric tape backing** — cut two strips of lining fabric, each 4 cm (1.5 in.) wide and the same length as the zipper. These will sandwich the zipper tape between the crochet and the lining.
- 3 Pin the zipper to the fabric strip** — place the zipper face-down on the right side of one fabric strip, aligning the top edges. Pin along the zipper tape.
- 4 Sew the zipper to the fabric strip** — backstitch along the zipper tape, about 3 mm from the teeth. Repeat with the second strip on the other side of the zipper.
- 5 Fold and press** — fold the fabric strips outward away from the teeth and press. The zipper is now sandwiched with clean fabric edges on both sides.

- 6 **Position inside the bag** — place the zipper assembly along the inside of the top opening. The fabric strips should sit against the inside of the crochet shell, with zipper teeth centered at the opening.
- 7 **Whip-stitch the fabric edges to the crochet** — stitch through the fabric strip edge (not through the zipper tape itself) and through the crochet stitches along the top row. This way, the zipper is anchored to the fabric, which is anchored to the crochet.
- 8 **Trim excess zipper length** — if the zipper extends beyond the side seams, fold the excess tape inward and tack it down with a few stitches. Add a thread bar or a small ribbon tab as a stopper.

Good Practice

Always attach the zipper to a fabric strip first, then attach the fabric strip to the crochet. Sewing a zipper directly to crochet stitches distorts them and creates uneven tension.

Common Mistake

Using a zipper that is shorter than the opening. A too-short zipper forces the crochet to bunch at the ends. Always go 2–3 cm longer and trim after installation.

Adding an Interior Zip Pocket

- 1 **Cut a pocket rectangle** — cut lining fabric to your desired pocket size plus 1.5 cm seam allowance on all sides.
- 2 **Mark the zipper opening** — on the lining panel (before assembly), draw a rectangle 1 cm shorter than the zipper and 1 cm tall, centered where you want the pocket.
- 3 **Sew around the marked rectangle** — stitch along the drawn lines. Cut through the center of the rectangle, snipping diagonally into the corners.
- 4 **Push the pocket fabric through** — turn the pocket piece through the opening to the wrong side. Press the edges flat.
- 5 **Pin and sew the zipper behind the opening** — position the zipper behind the pressed opening, right side facing through. Stitch around all four sides of the opening, catching the zipper tape.
- 6 **Fold and sew the pocket bag** — fold the pocket fabric into a bag shape behind the zipper. Stitch the three remaining sides closed.

Zipper Installation Check

- ☐ Zipper opens and closes smoothly without catching on yarn
- ☐ No visible warping or pulling of crochet stitches around the zipper
- ☐ Fabric tape backing is invisible from the outside of the bag
- ☐ Zipper ends are neatly finished with folded tape or thread bars
- ☐ Slider pull tab faces outward (not trapped inside the bag)

SECTION 5

Hardware: D-Rings, Clasps & Snaps

Choose and attach metal and plastic hardware that stays put under daily use.

Hardware turns crochet into a functional bag. The trick is anchoring each piece to a reinforced base — not to bare crochet stitches, which will stretch and pull through.

Hardware Types

D-Rings

A D-shaped metal or plastic ring that a strap clips onto. Sewn to the bag using a fabric or webbing tab.

Use for: adjustable shoulder straps, detachable straps.

Swivel Clasps (Lobster Clasps)

A spring-loaded clip that hooks onto a D-ring or O-ring. Allows the strap to rotate freely.

Use for: convertible bags (backpack to crossbody), keychains.

Magnetic Snaps

Two-part closures with a magnet. Installed through fabric with prongs and a washer on the back.

Use for: flap closures, easy open/close pockets.

Sew-On Snaps (Press Studs)

Two-part metal closures that click together. Sewn by hand through fabric with thread.

Use for: interior pockets, tab closures, lightweight flaps.

Slide Adjusters (Tri-Glides)

A three-bar buckle that allows strap length to be adjusted. Webbing threads through in a zigzag.

Use for: adjustable backpack straps, crossbody length.

Rivets

Two-part metal posts that punch through fabric and hammer flat. Permanent once set.

Use for: high-stress anchor points (strap bases, handle roots).

How to Attach a D-Ring

- 1 **Cut a fabric or webbing tab** — cut a strip of cotton webbing or folded lining fabric, 3–4 cm (1.25–1.5 in.) wide and 10 cm (4 in.) long.

- 2 **Thread the tab through the D-ring** — fold the strip in half through the flat side of the D-ring so both raw ends meet.
- 3 **Sew the raw ends together** — stitch across the raw ends with a box stitch (a rectangle with an X through it) for maximum strength.
- 4 **Position the tab on the bag** — place the sewn tab (raw ends down) against the inside of the bag at the strap attachment point. The D-ring should extend just above the top edge or side seam.
- 5 **Anchor to the crochet through lining** — stitch through the tab, the lining, and the crochet shell using a backstitch. Go around the rectangle twice for durability.

How to Install a Magnetic Snap

- 1 **Mark the position** — hold the snap where you want it. Push the prongs through to mark two small holes.
- 2 **Cut a reinforcement square** — cut a 3 cm × 3 cm (1.25 in. × 1.25 in.) piece of medium-weight interfacing or craft felt. This prevents the prongs from tearing through.
- 3 **Push prongs through** — push the snap prongs through the fabric and then through the reinforcement square on the back.
- 4 **Bend prongs flat** — place the metal washer over the prongs and bend each prong outward with pliers, pressing flat against the washer.
- 5 **Repeat for the second half** — install the matching half on the opposite piece (flap or body). Test the alignment by closing the snap before permanently bending the prongs.

Common Mistake

Pushing magnetic snap prongs directly through crochet fabric without a backing. The prongs will pull through the open stitches within days. Always use a fabric or interfacing backing behind the snap.

Hardware Attachment Check

- ☐ Every piece of hardware has a fabric or interfacing backing behind it
- ☐ D-ring tabs are box-stitched, not just straight-stitched
- ☐ Magnetic snap prongs are bent flat and do not poke through the lining
- ☐ Swivel clasps rotate freely on their rings without catching
- ☐ All hardware matches in finish (all nickel, all brass, or all matte black)

SECTION 6

Strap Reinforcement

Keep straps from stretching, sagging, or pulling out — even when the bag is fully loaded.

Crochet straps stretch under load. That is the nature of the material. Reinforcement is not optional for a bag you plan to carry daily — it is what separates a functional backpack from a decorative one.

Reinforcement Methods Compared

METHOD	TOOLS NEEDED	STRETCH PREVENTION	DIFFICULTY
Webbing backing	Cotton or nylon webbing, needle, thread	Excellent	Easy
Non-stretch cord core	Paracord or cotton cord, crochet hook	Very good	Easy (done during crocheting)
Rivets at anchor points	Rivet setter, hammer, cutting mat	Good (prevents pull-out)	Moderate
Interfacing strip	Fusible interfacing, iron	Moderate	Easy
Double-layered crochet	Extra yarn, hook	Moderate	Time-consuming

Method 1: Webbing Backing (Recommended)

- 1 Measure the strap length** — measure your finished crochet strap from end to end. Cut a piece of 2.5 cm (1 in.) cotton or nylon webbing to the same length.
- 2 Center the webbing on the back of the strap** — lay the crochet strap flat, wrong side up. Center the webbing along the length. Pin in place every 5 cm.
- 3 Whip-stitch both long edges** — sew the webbing to the strap along both long edges using matching thread. Stitch through the crochet back loops, not all the way through to the front.

- 4 Secure the ends** — fold the webbing ends under by 1 cm and stitch flat. These ends will be hidden at the anchor points.

Method 2: Non-Stretch Cord Core

- 1 Choose your cord** — use paracord (for thin straps) or cotton clothesline cord (for wider straps). The cord should be slightly shorter than the finished strap length to prevent sagging.
- 2 Crochet around the cord** — as you work the strap, lay the cord along the top of the previous row. Work your stitches over and around the cord so it becomes embedded inside the strap.
- 3 Anchor the cord ends** — at each end of the strap, fold the cord end back 2 cm and stitch it to itself with thread so it cannot slip out.

Good Practice

For bags that will carry more than 2–3 kg (5–7 lb), use both methods: crochet around a cord core, then add webbing on the back. The cord prevents lengthwise stretch; the webbing prevents widthwise distortion.

Securing Straps to the Bag

- 1 Reinforce the anchor zone on the bag** — add a 5 cm × 5 cm (2 in. × 2 in.) square of interfacing or doubled lining fabric to the inside of the bag at each strap attachment point.
- 2 Position the strap end** — overlap the strap end onto the bag body by at least 3 cm (1.25 in.).
- 3 Box-stitch through all layers** — stitch a rectangle shape, then an X through the rectangle, going through the strap, the reinforcement patch, the lining, and the crochet shell.
- 4 Optional: add a rivet** — place a rivet through the center of the box stitch for extra holding power. The rivet acts as a mechanical anchor; the stitching distributes the load.

Common Mistake

Attaching straps with only a few stitches at the very top of the bag. The weight of the contents concentrates on those stitches and they pull through. Always use a reinforced patch behind the anchor point and a box stitch pattern.

Strap Strength Check

- ☐ Straps do not visibly stretch when I pull on them with moderate force
- ☐ Anchor points have a reinforcement patch on the inside
- ☐ Box stitch (rectangle + X) is used at each attachment point
- ☐ No raw webbing or cord ends are exposed
- ☐ Straps are the same length on both sides (measure again after attachment)

SECTION 7

Drawstring Channels & Toggles

Create a smooth drawstring closure that cinches evenly and stays where you set it.

A drawstring channel added inside the top of a crochet bag gives you a secure closure without zippers or snaps. The key is making the channel wide enough that the cord slides freely.

Building the Channel

- 1 Decide the channel position** — the channel sits 2–4 rows below the top edge of the bag. Mark the row with stitch markers or scrap yarn.
- 2 Crochet method (built-in channel)** — on the chosen row, work a row of chain-space pairs: *skip 1 stitch, chain 1, single crochet in next stitch*. This creates evenly spaced eyelets for the cord to thread through. On the next row, work normally into both the chains and the single crochets.
- 3 Lining method (fabric casing)** — if you already have a lining, fold the top edge of the lining fabric down to create a 2.5 cm (1 in.) tube. Stitch the fold in place, leaving a 3 cm gap at the side seam for threading the cord. This method is smoother and snag-free.
- 4 Thread the cord** — attach a safety pin or bodkin to one end of the cord. Thread it through the channel, entering and exiting at the gap or eyelets.
- 5 Even out the cord** — pull both ends to the same length. The cord should cinch the opening evenly from both sides.

Cord and Toggle Options

CORD TYPE	DIAMETER	LOOK	BEST PAIRED WITH
Cotton cord (twisted)	4–5 mm	Natural, matte	Cotton yarn bags, bohemian style
Paracord (nylon)	3–4 mm	Sporty, smooth	Gym bags, kid packs, outdoor use
Leather cord / faux leather	3–4 mm	Premium, sleek	Structured bags, dressy designs
Crocheted i-cord	5–8 mm	Matching, soft	Any bag (matches the yarn exactly)

Attaching a Toggle or Cord Lock

- 1 **Choose your stopper** — a barrel cord lock (spring-loaded) is the most functional. A wooden bead toggle is decorative but requires knotting. Both work; choose by style.
- 2 **Thread both cord ends through the toggle** — for a barrel cord lock, push both ends through the same hole. For a bead toggle, thread each end through opposite holes.
- 3 **Knot below the toggle** — tie an overhand knot below the toggle to prevent the cord from slipping out. Leave 5–8 cm (2–3 in.) of cord tail below the knot.
- 4 **Finish the cord ends** — for cotton cord, wrap the end tightly with matching thread and secure with a drop of fabric glue. For paracord, melt the end briefly with a lighter to seal the fibers (do this over a non-flammable surface).

Good Practice

If the channel is crocheted (eyelet row), use a cord diameter that fills about 60–70% of the eyelet width. Too thin and it will not cinch evenly; too thick and it will jam.

Common Mistake

Making the channel too tight. If the cord barely fits, it will catch on yarn fibers every time you open the bag. Leave enough ease for the cord to slide back and forth freely.

Drawstring Check

- ☐ Cord slides freely through the entire channel without catching
- ☐ Opening cinches evenly from both sides
- ☐ Toggle or cord lock holds the cord in place when released
- ☐ Cord ends are finished (no fraying)
- ☐ The gap or eyelet entry point is neat and does not widen with use

SECTION 8

Troubleshooting Common Issues

Diagnose and fix the most frequent lining, zipper, and hardware problems before they ruin your project.

Most finishing problems come from one of three causes: wrong tension, missing reinforcement, or skipping pre-wash. This section covers the fixes.

Lining Problems

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Lining puckers at the top opening	Thread pulled too tight during whip-stitching	Remove the stitches in the puckered area. Re-sew with looser, even tension. The thread should lie flat, not pull the fabric inward.
Lining bunches at the bottom	Lining panels cut too tall	Remove tacking stitches, trim 1–2 cm from the bottom of the lining, re-sew the bottom seam, and tack again.
Lining shifts inside the bag	Only attached at the top, not tacked at the bottom	Add 3–4 tacking stitches at each bottom corner and one at the center of the base.
Lining shrinks after first wash	Fabric was not pre-washed before cutting	Remove the lining, re-wash it, re-press, re-cut if needed, and re-attach. Pre-wash all fabric from now on.
Lining fabric peeks above the crochet edge	Top fold is too narrow or lining is cut too tall	Remove the top stitches, fold the lining edge down another 0.5–1 cm, press, and re-stitch.

Zipper Problems

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Zipper warps the crochet fabric	Zipper sewn directly to crochet without a fabric tape backing	Remove the zipper. Sew it to fabric strips first, then re-attach the fabric strips to the crochet (Section 4 method).

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Zipper catches on yarn	Teeth are too close to exposed crochet stitches	Add a narrow fabric flap (1.5 cm wide) along each side of the zipper teeth to act as a guard between the zipper and the yarn.
Slider jams halfway	Fabric or yarn fiber is caught in the teeth	Gently work the slider back and forth while pulling the caught fiber free with a pin. Apply a thin coat of beeswax to the teeth to reduce friction.
Zipper does not lie flat	Zipper is shorter than the opening	Replace with a longer zipper (at least 2 cm longer than the opening) and trim the excess after installation.

Hardware Problems

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
D-ring pulls through the crochet	Attached directly to crochet without a fabric tab or reinforcement	Remove the D-ring. Attach it to a webbing or fabric tab, then anchor the tab to the bag with a reinforcement patch behind it (Section 5 method).
Magnetic snap tears through fabric	No interfacing or reinforcement behind the snap	Remove the snap. Add a square of interfacing or craft felt behind the installation point. Reinstall through both layers.
Snap does not align	Halves were installed independently without testing	Remove the misaligned half. Close the snap, hold it in place against the bag, and mark the correct position through the closed snap before reinstalling.
Rivet does not sit flat	Material is too thick or rivet shaft is too short	Use a longer rivet post, or reduce layers at the rivet point by trimming seam allowance in that spot. Rivet posts come in several lengths — match the post length to your combined material thickness.
Strap stretches after a few uses	No internal reinforcement (no webbing or cord core)	Remove the strap. Sew webbing to the back, or re-crochet the strap around a non-stretch cord. See Section 6.

General Rule

When in doubt, add a layer between the hardware and the crochet. A scrap of interfacing, a folded square of lining fabric, or a piece of webbing — any of these will distribute force across more stitches and prevent pull-through.

Quick Diagnosis Flowchart

Is It Puckering?

At the seam line: tension too tight → re-sew with looser stitches.

All over: lining shrank → re-wash, re-cut, re-attach.

Near hardware: snap or rivet pulling → add reinforcement behind.

Is Something Pulling Through?

Hardware: missing reinforcement → add interfacing or fabric patch.

Strap anchor: no box stitch → re-do with box stitch + patch.

Zipper end: no stopper → add a thread bar or fold and tack.

Final Quality Check

- ☐ Lining lies flat with no visible puckering from the outside
- ☐ All zippers open and close smoothly without catching
- ☐ All hardware is secure and does not wobble or rotate
- ☐ Straps hold weight without visible stretching
- ☐ Drawstring (if present) slides freely and cinches evenly
- ☐ No raw edges, loose threads, or exposed prongs inside the bag
- ☐ Bag has been test-loaded with weight for 10 minutes — nothing shifted

Next Step

Open the main pattern book, pick your first backpack project, and start crocheting the shell. When you reach the finishing stage, come back to this guide and work through each step — lining first, then zipper (if your pattern calls for one), then straps and hardware. Every technique here is designed to be followed in that order.